

FLIGHT PLAN
Models of the AMCA, one of DRDO's big-ticket aviation projects, at the Def Expo 2018

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DRDO, India's top defence research agency, has long been criticised for delayed projects and cost overruns. Now, a new committee tasked with revamping it is looking to change all that

From a room on the ground floor of the DRDO Bhawan in New Delhi—adjacent to the imposing pile of South Block—India's former top scientific advisor K. VijayRaghavan is speaking to a gathering of people involved in defence research. Tasked by the Prime Minister's Office (PMO), he is reviewing the role of the nation's premier defence research agency, the Defence Research and Development Organisation or DRDO, with the goal to fully revamp it, and has a November deadline to submit his report. To assist him, VijayRaghavan has an eight-member team drawn from the armed forces and industry. However, the absence of anyone from the DRDO itself in the panel has raised eyebrows in the agency headquarters. Besides restructuring DRDO's role, the VijayRaghavan committee—set up in the last week of August—is mandated to find solutions to attract and retain high-quality manpower through a system of incentives and disincentives and strict performance accountability. While embarking on this transformation of the DRDO, the Union government has in mind the example of the Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA) of the United States. Set up in 1958—the same year as DRDO—DARPA is a funding agency that makes "breakthrough investments for national security" and works with academic, industry and government R&D institutions. The ultimate goal is to inject professionalism in the DRDO, maximise academic and start-up participation and, through it all, address the chronic charges of delayed projects and cost overruns that tarnish its reputation.

The DRDO, which has a budget of Rs 23,264 crore in the budget estimate 2023-24, operates nearly 50 laboratories with a staff strength of around 30,000, of which 30 per cent are from the scientific community. In addition, there are over 20,000 contractual employees attached to DRDO labs. Within the DRDO, the Directorate of Futuristic Technology Management, started in 2019, aims to fund research projects in educational institutions, National Research Institutes and start-ups/ industry through a network of DRDO Industry Academia-Centres of Excellence (DIA-COEs). Essentially, it follows the same DARPA model, which is expected to be given a push by the VijayRaghavan panel.

Answering the charges of persistent delays, DRDO scientists argue that the armed forces keep changing goal posts by demanding deviations/ additions to developed technology. In fact, a few years back, the then defence minister Manohar Parrikar had said that the Indian military's requirements often resembled 'Marvel comic books' as they were "absurd, unrealistic and fanciful". The Light Combat Aircraft (LCA) Tejas and Main Battle Tank (MBT) Arjun are classic examples, in which the military's constant demand for upgrades played havoc on project timelines. Other projects that have been delayed include the LCA Mk-II, the Kaveri aero-engine and the Astra air-to-air missile. Nevertheless, over the years, defence scientists have not only received flak from the military fraternity but also from three parliamentary panels and the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG). The various committees, from the A.P.J. Abdul Kalam Committee

₹73,942 CRORE
Total sanctioned cost of DRDO's Mission Mode projects

23
DRDO Mission Mode projects behind schedule, out of 55 projects

49
DRDO projects where time taken was over 100 per cent of original schedule, per CAG report